



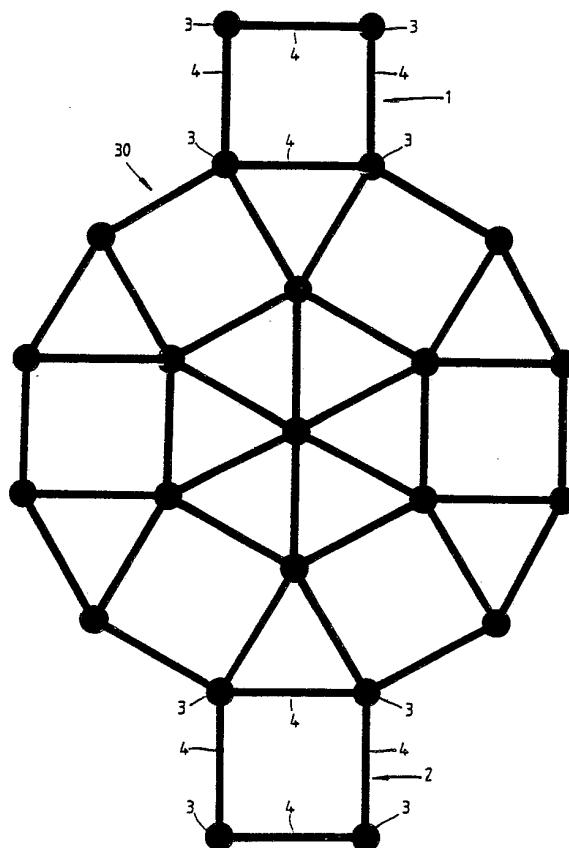
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(54) Title: APPARATUS FOR PLAYING A BOARD GAME

(57) Abstract

Apparatus for playing a board game comprises a board (30) having a number of home-base locations (1, 2), a number of inter-connecting pathways (4) extending between the home-base locations (1, 2) which define stopping points (3) at the interconnections of the pathways. The apparatus also comprises a number first playing pieces (9) for each player such that each player's first playing pieces (9) are adapted to be distinguished from other player's first playing pieces (9) and each player's first playing pieces are initially positioned at a home-base location (1, 2) and are advanced along the pathways via the stopping points (3) towards another predetermined home-base location (2). Whenever one player's playing pieces (5) are moved into a predetermined relationship with one or more of another player's playing pieces (6), that one or another player's playing pieces are removed from that one or another player's control, as the case may be. Typically, the apparatus further comprises a number of second playing pieces (10) for each player such that each player's second playing pieces are adapted to distinguish from other player's second playing pieces and from that player's first playing pieces. The second playing pieces (10) replace each of the first playing pieces (9) that reaches a predetermined home-base location and may be advanced along the pathways (4) via the stopping points (3) in any direction.



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APPARATUS FOR PLAYING A BOARD GAME

This invention relates to apparatus for playing a board game.

5 According to the present invention there is provided apparatus for playing a board game comprising a board having a number of home-base locations, a number of interconnecting pathways extending between the home-base locations and stopping points defined by the
10 interconnections of the pathways; the apparatus further comprising a number of first playing pieces for each player, each player's first playing pieces being capable of being distinguished from other players' first playing pieces, and for initial positioning at the home-base
15 locations and for advancing along the pathways via the stopping points.

 The invention enables the board game to be played so that whenever one player's playing pieces are moved into a predetermined relationship with one or more of another
20 player's playing pieces, that one or another player's playing pieces are removed from that one or another player's control, as the case may be.

 In the preferred embodiment the board has two home-base locations, although in an alternative
25 embodiment the board may have six home-base locations.

 Preferably, the stopping points are circular, although they could be a diamond shape or any other suitable shape, or even marked only by the interconnection of the pathways. Preferably, the
30 pathways are rectilinear. The pathways typically comprise lines which are marked on the board. Alternatively the lines may be used to define regions which are used, as stopping points, the pieces being moved across the lines into adjacent regions.

35 Typically, each first playing piece has a number of player indicating sides which carry respective different player indicators, whereby each piece can be placed on the board with any of its player indicating sides

uppermost.

In the preferred embodiment there are two player indicating sides on each first playing piece, each player indicating side being a different colour. Preferably
5 one side is black and the other is white, although the sides may be strongly contrasting shades of another colour.

In an alternative embodiment each first playing piece is a cube which has six player indicating sides
10 which are different colours.

Preferably, there is at least as many player indicating sides on each first playing piece as there are home-base locations on the board.

Preferably, the playing pieces for each player are
15 for advancing along the pathways via the stopping points only in a direction towards the other of the home-base locations, respectively. The apparatus also preferably includes a number of second playing pieces for each player, with each player's second pieces being capable of
20 being distinguished from other player's second playing pieces and from the first playing pieces, for replacing each of the first playing pieces that reaches the other of the home-base locations and for advancing along the pathways via the stopping points in any direction.

Typically, each second playing piece has two player
25 indicating sides, each player indicating side having a major, player indicating section and a minor section for distinguishing the piece from a first playing piece. Preferably the major and minor sections are different
30 colours, although the minor section could be provided by an emblem or other distinguishing mark.

Alternatively, each of the first playing pieces may be advanced along the pathways via the stopping points in any direction after having reached another predetermined
35 home-base location and wherein the first playing pieces are adapted to indicate whether they are intended to be advanced only in a direction towards a predetermined home-base location or in any direction.

In order that the invention may be more readily understood, an embodiment in accordance therewith will now be described with reference to the accompanying drawings, wherein:-

5 Figure 1 shows a diagrammatic representation of a playing board,

 Figure 2 shows schematically both sides of a playing piece,

10 Figure 3 shows schematically both sides of another playing piece, and

 Figures 4 and 5 respectively show schematically another embodiment of the playing pieces and board, in accordance with the invention.

 Referring to Figure 1, the playing board comprises
15 two home-bases 1,2 located at opposite ends of the board and each consisting of four stopping points, such as shown at 3, joined by four pathways in the form of lines, such as shown at 4, in the formation of a square. An imaginary extension both sides of the line
20 between the outermost stopping points at each end is called the "home-base line". Between the two homebases is a network of 34 interconnecting pathways also in the form of lines defining the locations of 15 further stopping points at the interconnections of the lines.

25 The lines are all of _____

1 equal length, so that the stopping points are equally
spaced from all adjacent stopping points, the term
"adjacent" stopping points being used to define
stopping points linked by a single line and "non-
5 adjacent" stopping points therefore meaning stopping
points linked by two or more intervening lines and at
least one other stopping point.

The lines in the central region of the network
form a regular hexagon with opposite corners joined by
10 straight lines to form equilateral triangles. An outer
square is formed on each side of the hexagon and the
other adjacent corners of the squares are joined by
further lines, including one from each of the home-
bases, to form six more equilateral triangles to
15 complete a regular dodecagon.

For small or pocket-size boards, the length of
each line is preferably 2.5 cm and the overall length
of the representation on the board is preferably
14.33 cm. In medium-sized boards, the length of the
20 representation is preferably about 32 cm and in large
size boards preferably about 40 cm.

One set of playing pieces consists of a plurality
of disc-shaped, reversible tokens known as "common"
pieces or "cobs", uniformly constructed so as to be
25 indistinguishable from each other. Each face 5,6 of one of
these tokens is shown in Figure 2, wherein it can be
seen that one face 5 is coloured a dark colour and the
other face 6 is coloured a light colour. Pieces with
the light-coloured side facing upwards are known as
30 "white" and pieces with the dark-coloured side facing
upwards are known as "black". The light and dark

1 colours may actually be white and black, respectively,
or any two strongly contrasting shades of the same
colour.

A second set of playing pieces consists of a
5 plurality of tokens 10, each face 11, 12 of one of which is shown
in Figure 3. It can be seen that these pieces are
constructed and coloured similar to the "cob" pieces 9,
except for a contrasting mark, 7, 8, such as a centrally-
positioned spot, or an emblem on each face 11, 12 thereof. The
10 playing pieces of the second set are known as "royal"
pieces or "roks".

The diameters of all the playing pieces should be
the same and related to the board size. Preferably, a
line between adjacent stopping points on the board is
15 of length between two- and one-eighth and two-and
one-quarter of the diameter of the playing pieces, so
that one playing piece should be able to pass closely,
but comfortably, between two other pieces placed
centrally on adjacent points without touching either of
20 them. The playing pieces of both sets are preferably of
thickness not more than half of their diameter for use
on small boards and not less than one-fifth of their
diameter for use on medium or large size boards. The
width of the lines should be not more than one-eighth of
25 the diameter of the pieces, and the stopping points, if
emphasised, should be of diameter less than one half of
the diameter of the playing pieces. The overall length
of the representation on the board is determined as
 $S(4 + \tan 60^\circ)$, where S is the distance between
30 adjacent points. The board may be painted, printed, or
inlaid in solid material, and the representation and

1 background are of contrasting shades, which are preferably the same as, or similar to, those used for the playing pieces. Additional marks or colours may also be used to distinguish each end of the board.

5 The board and playing pieces are designed and constructed for two players, each being associated with one of the two colours of the playing pieces and one of the home-bases. The board and playing pieces, in accordance with the invention, may be used to play several different games, one aim of which typically, is to
10 capture or immobilise the opponents playing pieces. The rules for each of the games are as follows.

In the first game, eight reversible "cob" pieces 9 and eight reversible "rok" pieces 10 are used.

At the beginning of the first game, a white "cob" piece is placed on each of the four stopping points of one home-base and a black "cob" piece on each of the four points of the other home-base. The players move their pieces alternately, with the white "cob" pieces
15 playing first, by advancing a "cob" piece from one stopping point along a line in the direction of the opponents home-base to an adjacent stopping point. A
20 "cob" piece can only be moved to a point nearer the opponents "home-base line" except when such a piece begins a move on one of its own home-base stopping points, in which
25 case it can be moved in any direction to effect a capture, as described hereinafter. No piece may be moved to a stopping point occupied by another piece.

When a piece is moved from a non-adjacent stopping point to a stopping point adjacent an opponent's piece,
30 it is said to have captured that. _____

1 piece. The captured piece remains on the same stopping point but is turned over, so that its opposite face is upwards, to show the opposite colour, and subsequently belongs to the player who has captured it.

5 More than one piece may be captured by the same move, but no piece may be captured by a piece which was adjacent it before the move.

A "cob" piece is promoted to a "rok" piece when it is advanced onto an opponent's home-base stopping point, and the "cob" piece is removed from the board and a "rok" piece having the same colour facing upwards is substituted. A "cob" piece captured on one of its own home-base stopping points is not immediately promoted, but becomes a "cob" piece of the opposite colour by turning it over on the opponent's home-base point. It is then promoted if it is later advanced. Unlike a "cob" piece, a "rok" piece can move in any direction along the lines.

A "cob" piece on one of its opponent's two outermost home-base stopping points cannot be advanced and is said to be "dead". A "cob" piece, the only legal path of which is blocked by a "dead" piece, is also "dead". A piece is not necessarily "dead" if it cannot be moved. For example, no "rok" piece can be "dead", and a "cob" piece, the path of which is blocked by a "cob" piece of the opposite colour, or by a "live" "cob" piece of the same colour, or by a "rok" piece of either colour, is not "dead". A player, who cannot move any of his pieces, but who possesses one or more "dead" pieces, may promote one of them to a "rok" piece, if this permits it to be moved. A player with a "cob"

1 piece, which is the sole remaining piece of its colour,
must promote it in any case, wherever it is positioned.

The game terminates in a win for one player or a
draw. A player wins if, firstly, the opponent cannot
5 legally move any of his pieces, or secondly the
opponent resigns or abandons the game, or thirdly, if a
time limit is imposed for performing a set number of
moves, the opponent fails to complete the required
number of moves in the time limit. The game is drawn if
10 firstly the players agree a draw. Secondly, the game is
drawn, if the moves of the game have been recorded and
a player can prove that at least fifty consecutive
moves, including the move last played, have been played
by each player without moving or promoting a "cob"
15 piece. This draw may not however be claimed, regardless
of the count, if a player has already won the game or
can win, because the opponent cannot legally move any
piece, at the next opportunity to play. Thirdly, the
game is drawn if a player correctly announces that, at
20 the completion of his next intended move, the resulting
position will have occurred at least three times.
Pieces of the same rank and colour must occupy
identical stopping points and it must be the same
players turn to play on each occasion. If the claim is
25 incorrect, the announced move, if legal, must be played
and the game continues without prejudice to the
claimants right to re-claim the draw at a later stage.

The moves can be recorded using any suitable
notations and by labelling or numbering the stopping
30 points, for example, in a similar manner to map
references.

1 In the second game, only one set of playing pieces
is used, preferably consisting of 22 reversible pieces
having light and dark colours on respective faces.
As with the first game, each player chooses a light or
dark colour and places a piece on each of his four
5 home-base stopping points. Again, the player with the
lighter coloured pieces begins by advancing a piece
along a line to an adjacent stopping point. Also, in
accordance with the "cob" pieces of the first game, the
pieces must move towards the opponent's "home-base line"
10 and no piece can move to a stopping point already
occupied.

 If a piece finishes its move adjacent one or more
opposing pieces, the player must pay that number of
pieces, known as "penalty" pieces, to the opponent, by
15 placing them on stopping points on the board, except
that they may not be placed adjacent any of the player's
own pieces or nearer the player's home base-line than the
opponent's most advanced piece. If the player cannot
place all the "penalty" pieces, he must place as many as
20 possible and then pay the difference by removing his
own pieces from the board. If it is not possible for a
player to advance any of his pieces, he must remove one of
them from the board. A player wins when the opponent has
no pieces left on the board.

25 If a position is repeated, with neither player
willing to break the sequence of moves that led to it,
some means involving chance, such as a coin or dice,
may be used to determine which player must break the
sequence. The winner of matches, where more than one
30

1 game is played, can be decided by counting either the number of games won, or the number of pieces remaining on the board when each game has ended, which are then used as points towards a final score for the match.

5 Whilst a particular embodiment has been described, it will be understood that modifications can be made without departure from the scope of the invention. For example, some of the lines of the board can be curved rather than straight, so as to form
10 circles, instead of the hexagon and dodecagon, or alternatively any other formation of interconnecting lines and points may be utilised. Also, the stopping points, which are emphasised on the representation shown in the figure, may be a shape other than
15 circular, such as a square or diamond. Alternatively, the stopping points may be formed merely by the meeting of the lines, with no specific emphasis thereof. Instead of using reversible playing pieces, playing pieces having a uniform colour may be used, with
20 different coloured pieces being provided for each player, in which case twice the number of pieces for two players will be required. In this way, more than two players could play at any one time and also more than two home-bases can be provided around the
25 periphery of the board. Alternatively, for the first game, each playing piece could be uniformly coloured with an emblem or other contrasting mark on one face thereof, so that a single playing piece can be used as both a "cob" piece and a "rok" piece for each player.

1 Playing pieces having more than two sides may be used
for more than two players, with each face being
differently coloured or otherwise marked for each player.
In this way, for example, a cubic playing piece, 13 as shown in
Figure 4, with each of its faces (only three shown) being differently
5 coloured may be used for up to six players, each player
having his colour facing upwards when the playing piece
is on the board. A particular modification of the board
for up to six players is shown by the diagrammatic
representation in Figure 5. It can be seen that the board 25
10 has six home-base locations equally spaced around the
board, with a larger network of lines 4 therebetween.

In a game using the board 25 and cubic playing pieces 13
shown in Figures 4 and 5, the players begin by each
placing four playing pieces with their respective coloured
15 face facing upwards, on their respective home-base. If
less than six players are playing, home-bases spaced as
evenly as possible around the board should be selected.
The players advance their playing pieces, in turn, along
the lines 4 to the stopping points 3, as in the above-described
20 games, in any direction, except that an initial move from
a home-base stopping point must be along one of the lines
forming a square immediately adjacent that home-base.
Playing pieces are captured, as in the above-described
games, by a players playing piece being moved adjacent one
25 or more of another player's playing pieces. The other players'
cubic playing pieces are then turned over so that the first
player's colour is facing upward. A player who cannot
move any of his playing pieces or all his playing pieces
have been captured retires from the game. If this player
30 has any of his pieces remaining on the board, they are
removed. When only two players remain in the game, the
game ends and the winner is the one with the most pieces
left on the board, or if the number of pieces are equal,
both players share the winning position.

CLAIMS

1. Apparatus for playing a board game comprising a board (30;25) having a number of home-base locations (1,2; 17-22), a number of interconnecting pathways (4) extending between the home-base locations (1,2; 17-22) and stopping points (3) defined by the interconnections of the pathways (4); the apparatus further comprising a number of first playing pieces (9;13) for each player, each player's first playing pieces being capable of being distinguished from other players' first playing pieces, and for initial positioning at the home-base locations (1,2) and for advancing along the pathways (4) via the stopping points (3).
2. Apparatus according to claim 1, wherein the board (25) has six home-base locations (17,18,19,20,21,22).
3. Apparatus according to claim 1, wherein the board (30) has two home-base locations (1,2).
4. Apparatus according to claim 1, wherein each first playing piece (9;13) has a number of player indicating sides (5,6) which carry respective different player indicators, whereby each piece can be placed on the board with any of its player indicating sides uppermost.
5. Apparatus according to claim 4, wherein there are two player indicating sides (5,6).
6. Apparatus according to claim 4, wherein there are six player indicating sides.
7. Apparatus according to claim 4, wherein the respective different player indicators are provided by different colours.
8. Apparatus according to claim 5, wherein the player indicators are two strongly contrasting shades of the same colour.
9. Apparatus according to claim 8, wherein one shade is white and the other shade is black.

10. Apparatus according to claim 4, wherein each first playing piece (9;13) has at least the same number of player indicating sides as the number of home-base locations (1,2; 17-22) on the board (25;30).
- 5 11. Apparatus according to claim 1, wherein the stopping points (3) are circular.
12. Apparatus according to claim 1, wherein the pathways (4) are rectilinear.
13. Apparatus according to claim 1, further comprising a
- 10 number of second playing pieces (10) for each player, each player's second playing pieces being capable of being distinguished from other player's second playing pieces and from that player's first playing pieces (9).
14. Apparatus according to claim 13, wherein each second
- 15 playing piece (10) has a number of player indicating sides (11,12), each player indicating side having a major player indicating section (11,12) and a minor section (7,8) for distinguishing each second playing piece (10) from a first playing piece (9).
- 20 15. Apparatus according to claim 14, wherein the major player indicating section (11,12) and the minor section (7,8) are different colours.
16. Apparatus according to claim 14, wherein each second playing piece has six player indicating sides.
- 25 17. Apparatus according to claim 14, wherein each second playing piece has two player indicating sides.
18. Apparatus according to claim 17, wherein the player indicating sections are two strongly contrasting shades of the same colour.
- 30 19. Apparatus according to claim 18, wherein the shade of one player indicating section is white and the shade of the other player indicating section is black.
20. Apparatus according to claim 1, wherein the first playing pieces may be advanced along the pathways (4) via
- 35 the stopping points (3) in any direction after having

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reached another predetermined home-base location and
wherein the first playing pieces are adapted to indicate
whether they are intended to be advanced only in a
direction towards a predetermined home-base location or
5 in any direction.

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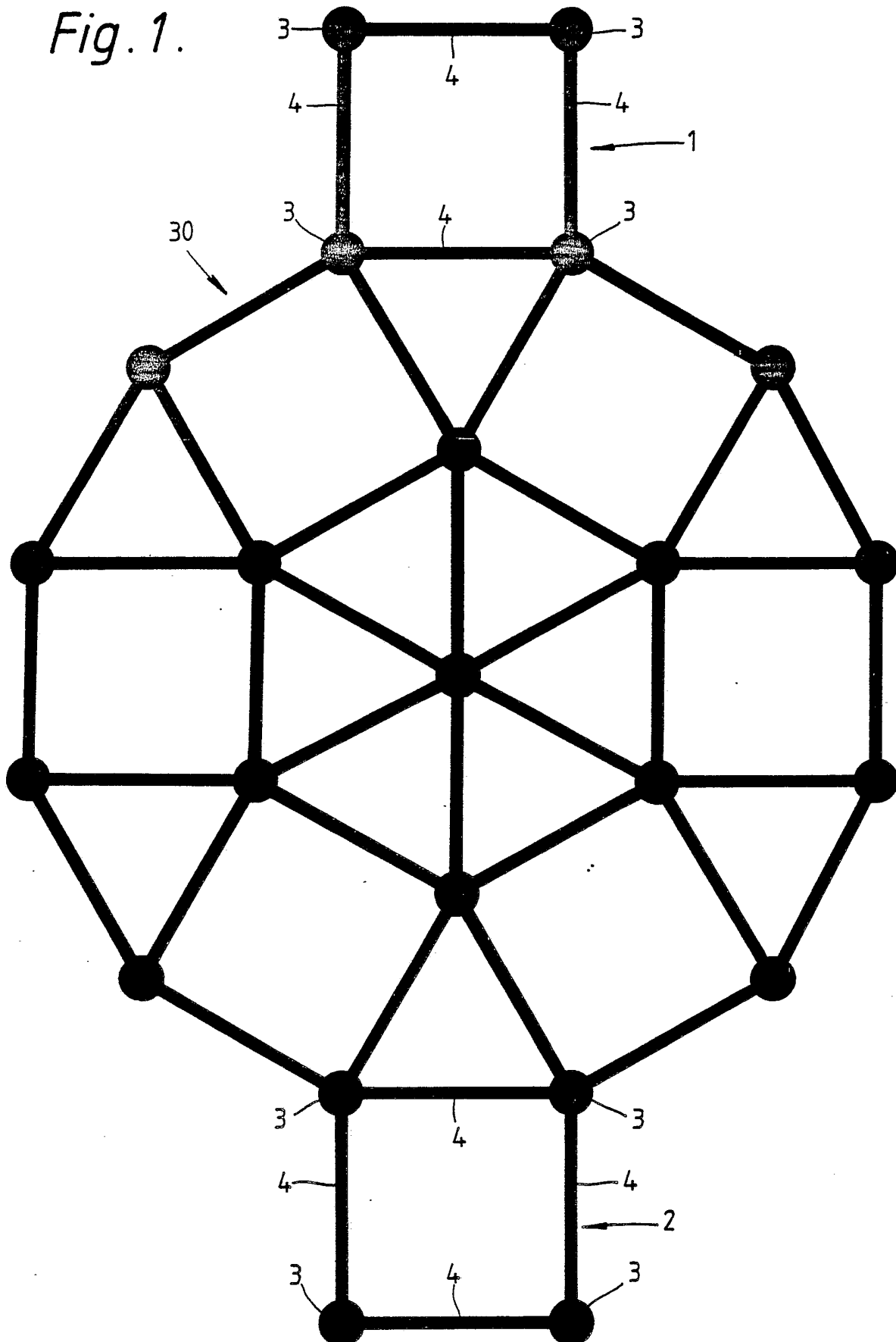
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Fig. 1.



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Fig. 2.

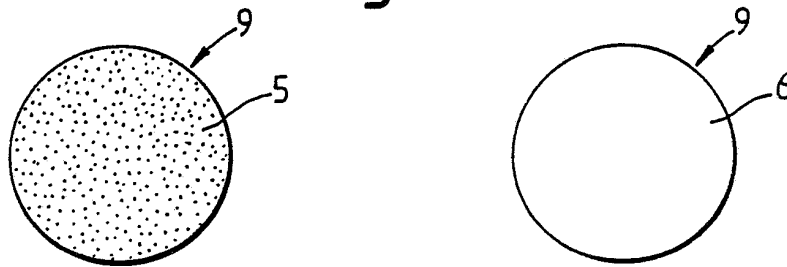


Fig. 3.

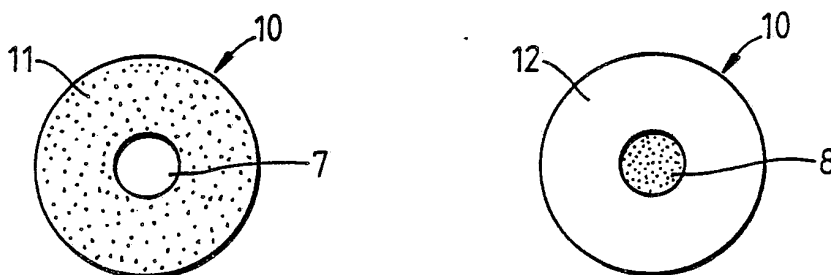
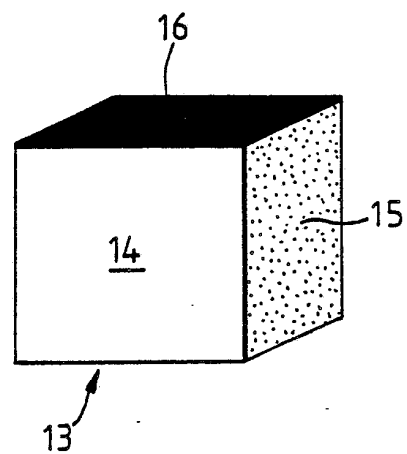
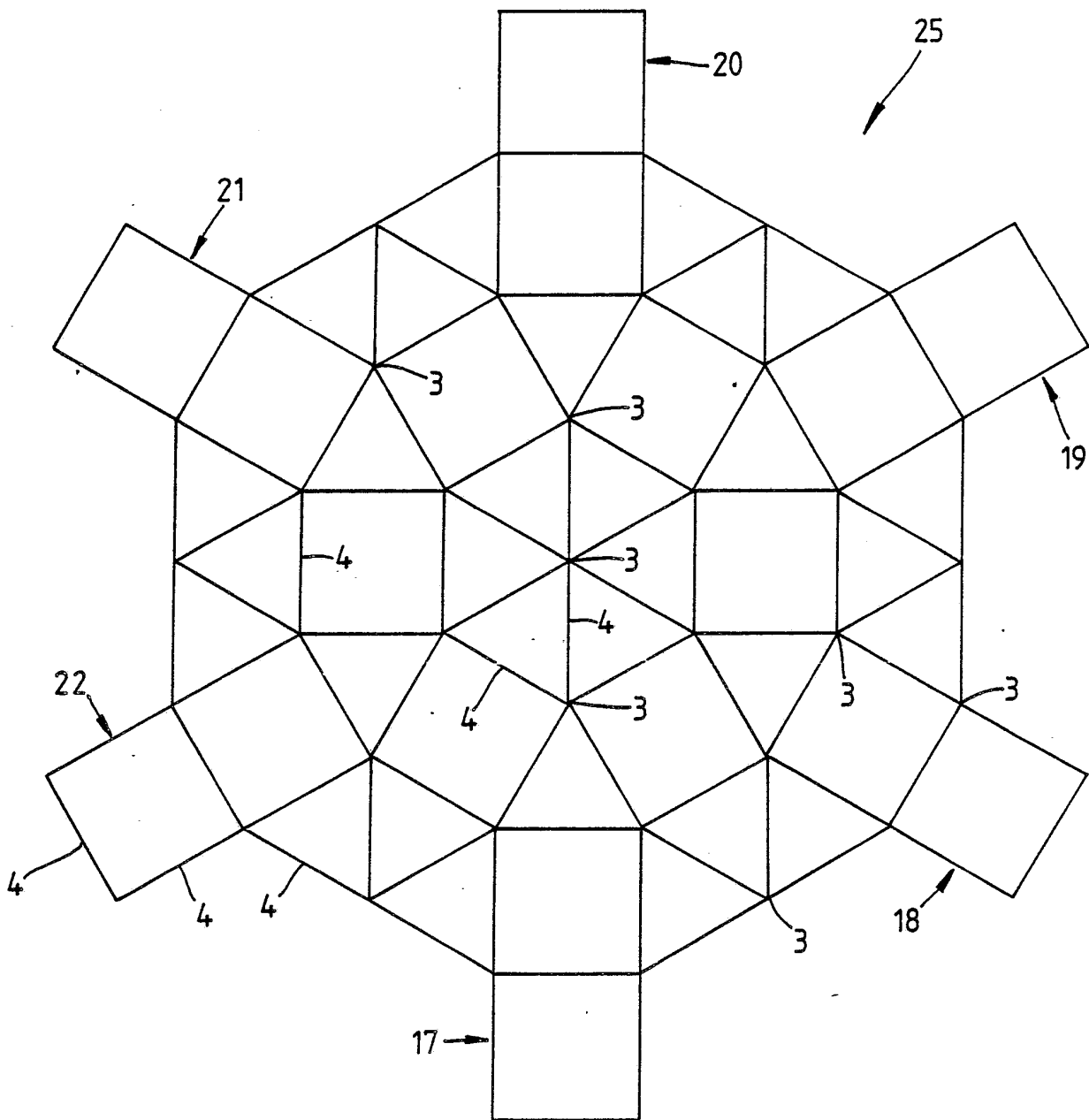


Fig. 4.



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Fig. 5.

INTERNATIONAL SEARCH REPORT

International Application No PCT/GB 88/00774

I. CLASSIFICATION OF SUBJECT MATTER (if several classification symbols apply, indicate all) *		
According to International Patent Classification (IPC) or to both National Classification and IPC		
IPC ⁴ : A 63 F 3/02		
II. FIELDS SEARCHED		
Minimum Documentation Searched ⁷		
Classification System	Classification Symbols	
IPC ⁴	A 63 F	
Documentation Searched other than Minimum Documentation to the Extent that such Documents are Included in the Fields Searched *		
III. DOCUMENTS CONSIDERED TO BE RELEVANT *		
Category *	Citation of Document, ¹¹ with indication, where appropriate, of the relevant passages ¹²	Relevant to Claim No. ¹³
Y	US, A, 4190256 (RUDDEN, JR) 26 February 1980, see column 3, lines 17-28, 66-68; column 4, lines 17-19; figures	1-20
Y	US, A, 4391449 (JOHNSON) 5 July 1983, see column 3, lines 3-17, 23-31; figures 3-5b	1-20
Y	US, A, 4067578 (CHANG) 10 January 1978, see column 2, lines 18-24; figure 2	6
A	FR, A, 1145522 (CALABRO) 28 October 1957, see figure	1, 3, 11
A	US, A, 2843385 (HAUSLER) 15 July 1958, see column 2, lines 54-57; figures 1, 4	1, 4, 11, 13

* Special categories of cited documents: ¹⁰ "A" document defining the general state of the art which is not considered to be of particular relevance "E" earlier document but published on or after the international filing date "L" document which may throw doubts on priority claim(s) or which is cited to establish the publication date of another citation or other special reason (as specified) "O" document referring to an oral disclosure, use, exhibition or other means "P" document published prior to the international filing date but later than the priority date claimed "T" later document published after the international filing date or priority date and not in conflict with the application but cited to understand the principle or theory underlying the invention "X" document of particular relevance; the claimed invention cannot be considered novel or cannot be considered to involve an inventive step "Y" document of particular relevance; the claimed invention cannot be considered to involve an inventive step when the document is combined with one or more other such documents, such combination being obvious to a person skilled in the art. "&" document member of the same patent family		
IV. CERTIFICATION		
Date of the Actual Completion of the International Search	Date of Mailing of this International Search Report	
8th December 1988	30.12.88	
International Searching Authority	Signature of Authorized Officer	
EUROPEAN PATENT OFFICE	P.C.G. VAN DER PUTTEN	

ANNEX TO THE INTERNATIONAL SEARCH REPORT
ON INTERNATIONAL PATENT APPLICATION NO.

GB 8800774

SA 24389

This annex lists the patent family members relating to the patent documents cited in the above-mentioned international search report. The members are as contained in the European Patent Office EDP file on 27/12/88. The European Patent Office is in no way liable for these particulars which are merely given for the purpose of information.

Patent document cited in search report	Publication date	Patent family member(s)	Publication date
US-A- 4190256	26-02-80	None	
US-A- 4391449	05-07-83	None	
US-A- 4067578	10-01-78	None	
FR-A- 1145522		None	
US-A- 2843385		None	